

■ By Subhash Mishra

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati and her predecessor Mulayam Singh Yadav love to hate each other, but they have one common characteristic—dumping political friends once they have outgrown their utility.

Till some time back, Mayawati was having a cosy time with the Congress-led UPA Government at the Centre. Now, taking inspiration from CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, she too has aimed a pistol at the Congress and is threatening to pull the trigger if the Centre doesn't acquiesce. Her most recent grudge is that the Centre has not acceded to her demand for a Rs 80,000-crore special package for the socio-economic development of the Dalits, minorities, OBCs and the impoverished regions of the state, particularly Bundelkhand and Purvanchal. The Dalit leader stunned politicians when she lambasted the UPA Government for the delay in sanctioning the special package for the state. Addressing an election meeting while campaigning for Anant Kumar Mishra, BSP candidate for the Farrukhabad Assembly byelection, Mayawati warned the Central Government that her party would sever ties with it if her demand for a special package was not conceded soon. "I have met the prime minister twice and sent reminders too in this regard, but they are just sitting over it," says the chief minister.

That she meant business was obvious when she made a scathing attack on Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee (UPCC) President Salman Khurshid and said, "*Yeh agar Musalmaano ka humdard hota to ek Christian se shaadi kyon karta* (Had he been a sympathiser of the Muslims why would he have married a Christian)?" The statement rattled the Congress leadership even though her penchant for making such volatile and controversial comments is known—specially so when she delivers unwritten speeches during election campaigns.

However, the Congress accuses the chief minister of "telling lies". "Her special package of Rs 80,000 crore is nothing but funds for the state for the next five years under the 11th Five-Year Plan. I have a copy of the letter from the



FOR A FEW RUPEES

Mayawati's ultimatum to the UPA Government over development funds is yet another attempt to distance herself from the Congress

chief minister to the prime minister. It is not a special package at all," state Congress spokesman Akhilesh Pratap Singh told INDIA TODAY. "This is Soniaji's state, there would be no paucity of funds for development in Uttar Pradesh," Singh added, saying that in the last two years the Centre had given the state Rs 30,000 crore and most of the funds had remained unutilised.

In fact, the Congress leadership is baffled over Mayawati's repeated demand for quick release of funds. "She is asking for funds like a wayward child insisting on pocket money from parents," said a Union minister during a visit to Lucknow, highlighting the growing tension between BSP and the UPA Government.

If the BSP-Congress relationship has to end, it will not be due to the 'delay' by the Centre in sanctioning the special package. First, there is no delay on the

part of the Centre as the prime minister has already constituted a special committee under the chairmanship of former cabinet secretary B.K. Chaturvedi to scrutinise the demand of the Uttar Pradesh Government. Second, the first round of meeting between the Central and the state government officials in this regard has already been held in Delhi and a second round is to be held soon.

In fact, her fourth inning as the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh does not reflect any serious concern for the development of the most populated state in the country. In her first 100 days in office, Mayawati has not announced or implemented any public welfare programme. Rather, those which were announced earlier have been rolled back. Whether it was the new agriculture policy, contract farming, retail business by big corporate houses or hi-tech